

LIGHTBULB MOMENT



Shine a light into a comic strip, swap what the characters are thinking, and watch the punchline twist.

COMIC

TWIST

LIGHT

THE PITCH

LIGHTBULB MOMENT is a comic-book puzzle game. You play a mischievous lightbulb loose inside a newspaper comic. Each page first plays its **original, predictable punchline**, then a red pen strikes it out and demands a twist.

You can't move anyone. You only decide **who is lit**, which controls who acts and what they can see, and you **swap the thoughts** in their heads. Press **ACTION** and your edit sets off a slapstick chain reaction until the final panel matches the twisted caption.

CORE LOOP



COMIC

THE COMIC IS THE INTERFACE

- **Thought bubbles are the game pieces.** You drag them from head to head.
- The **lightbulb over a head** (comic shorthand for an idea) is the activation rule.
- The **panel border is the world's edge**: scared characters burst out of the story.
- Onomatopoeia is the feedback, and **every run is laid out as its own comic strip**.

LIGHT

THE CORE RULE AND THE SCARCE RESOURCE

- **Only lit characters act.** Spotlights (1–2 per page, each 3 slots wide) choose your actors.
- **Characters only see what's lit.** Food in the dark is invisible, so darkness steers who goes where.
- You can only swap thoughts between **two lit characters**.
- **Floor switches turn on lamps** mid-scene, waking new characters and spreading the chain.

TWIST

YOU EDIT AN ENDING, NOT A BLANK LEVEL

- Each page starts from a **working story** that produces the original punchline.
- Your goal is that punchline **corrected in red pen**, and it is always a **role reversal**.
- The Original is **evidence** for thoughts your light can't reach.
- Light reveals **contradictions**: the meek Intern is **ANGRY**, sweet Grandma is **SCARED**.

PLAYER EXPERIENCE

- **Puzzle solving**: arrange light and thoughts. Thoughts can only be swapped, never created, so every fix creates a new actor to deal with.
- **Prediction**: footprints show each lit character's first move. You reason out the rest.
- **Experimentation**: runs last under 10 seconds, REWIND keeps your plan, and there are no lives or penalties.
- **Chain reactions**: scares, switches, lamps and races won by a single step.
- **Comedy and payoff**: CHOMP!, BONK!, ZOOM!, funny auto-written captions for failures, and a TWIST! stamp for wins.

EXAMPLE

PAGE 6 · THE BOSS'S BIRTHDAY

ORIGINAL

The spotlight is on the Boss. He walks to the cake: **CHOMP!**
"The Boss ate the birthday cake."

YOUR EDIT

Light reveals sweet Grandma is **SCARED**. Swap her thought with the Boss's **HUNGRY**, then move the light onto Grandma and the Boss.

TWIST

Boss flees → steps on pedal **CLICK!** →
lamp on **DING!** → Dog sees cake →
CHOMP!
"The ~~Boss~~ **DOG** ate the Boss's cake. The Boss ran out of the comic." **TWIST!**

GAMEPLAY SYSTEM

- **Stage:** a single side-view row of 7–12 slots inside one comic panel. The panel border is the edge of the world.
- **Characters** (Boss, Dog, Cat, Grandma, Kid, Intern...) all follow the same rules. Their personality comes from art and reactions.
- **Each character holds exactly one of four thoughts:**

HUNGRY
Walks to the nearest visible food and eats it.

SLEEPY
Walks to the nearest free seat and falls asleep.

ANGRY
Goes after the nearest standing character. BONK!

SCARED
Flees from anyone close, right out of the comic.
- **Light:** movable spotlights, fixed lights (fireplace, fridge) and switch-wired lamps decide who acts and what can be seen.
- **Planning:** while you plan, moving the light or swapping thoughts updates each character's intent instantly. ACTION locks the plan.
- **Deterministic resolution:** the whole run is simulated beat by beat, then played back. The same plan always gives the same result, so runs are fair, fast and skippable.
- **Endings:** goals are simple facts (who ate, slept, bonked or ran away). Every run, won or failed, ends in its own captioned final panel.

WHY IT STANDS OUT

- **Themes are the rules.** Remove the light and the game falls apart. The comic is the interface, and the twist is the goal.
- **Simple input, emergent depth:** just three actions (place light, swap, ACTION), with chain reactions arising from the system.
- **Every run becomes a comic strip.** Even failures are funny and worth watching.
- **Readable puzzles:** no hidden randomness, only cause and effect you can follow.
- **High polish potential:** one small rule set, so the jam time goes into feel, not volume.

VISUAL & ART DIRECTION

- **A living newspaper comic page:** bold panels, gutters and caption boxes.
- **Planning in pencil, committed in ink:** pressing ACTION inks the panel.
- **Dramatic lighting:** navy halftone darkness, warm spotlight cones, lit areas in full colour.
- **Thought bubbles** combine icon, colour and word, so they stay readable for colour-blind players.
- **Impact frames:** bold onomatopoeia and a DING that rises in pitch along each chain.
- The Editor's **red pen** corrects each punchline, and wins are collected on a "Sunday Edition" newspaper page.

DEVELOPMENT SCOPE REALISTIC FOR 100 HOURS

- **Core first:** three key pages (Nap Time, Midnight Snack, The Boss's Birthday) are built and playtested before anything else.
- **Up to 8 short pages** in total, each teaching one idea. More are added only after a playtest confirms the core is fun.
- **Reusable systems:** one uniform rule set and cosmetic characters keep content cheap. Captions and strips are generated from events.
- **Strong onboarding:** almost no text, each mechanic shown in an Original before it is needed, ghost-hand hints, and a skip option after 3 failures.
- **Polish over volume:** game feel, light rendering, impact frames and instant rewind come before extra content.
- **Out of scope:** multiplayer, procedural levels, a level editor, physics.

Status: the design is complete. All features described in this proposal are planned for the jam build, and none are claimed as implemented.
Engine: Godot. Target: a web build on itch.io.

TEAM

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